

"fragment" be accounted for? At present it plays a very important part in helping to connect the Story of the Youths with the Hebrew narrative 5: 7 ff. (=Ezra 2: 1 ff.). Its points of affinity with either section are obvious, and certainly not accidental. It sounds as though it were of one piece with the verses which immediately follow it, as well as with those which immediately precede it; and as for the Three Youths, there is an express allusion to them (somewhat parenthetical, to be sure) in vs. 6. But what end this passage of six verses may have served when connected with neither portion of its present context, no one, so far as I know, has ever ventured to guess. Of course, if the Episode of the Youths were originally written in Greek, it would follow that these six verses must have belonged to an entirely separate document. As for the following narrative (the Chronicler's), if this passage (5: 1-6) originally formed a part of it, how has it disappeared from our canonical book? And if it did not originally belong to it, how in the world can it have been detached from its proper surroundings and brought to this place? Guthe's amazing suggestion (Kautzsch's *Apokryphen*, p. 2) that it was composed by "the redactor" (!) certainly needs no refutation. The passage bears no resemblance whatever to an editorial patch. Nor is any theory of an isolated fragment plausible. We are not driven to any such strait as this, that we should be obliged to postulate a lost narrative of a return of Jews from Babylonia, written in Hebrew and translated into Greek, and now surviving only in these six verses! There is a far simpler hypothesis. Just as soon as it is observed that the Greek of this passage is the result of translation, it becomes probable that the Story of the Youths was incorporated in a Semitic form.

There is still other important evidence of this nature pointing to the same conclusion. The latter part of chap. 4 cannot so easily be separated from the first part of chap. 5. There is no perceptible break, nor anything to make it probable that two separate documents are joined at this point. The two concluding verses of chap. 4 cannot have formed the end of a piece of narrative. The closing words of verse 63, "and they feasted *seven days*," make it plain that their author intended to narrate what took place after the seven days. And in like manner the first words of 5:1, "*After this* there were chosen," etc., presuppose the words which just precede them. The two parts agree per-